nurture.

Invasive species A nonnative species that, introduced to an ecosystem, spreads rapidly, damaging the ecological balance of the area.

Irrigation The controlled application of water to areas of land, usually through the creation of channels, to help crops grow.

Keystone species A species that plays a centrally important role in an ecosystem, often disproportionate to its biomass, and whose removal would alter or endanger the entire ecosystem.

Kin selection An evolutionary strategy whereby individuals pursue the best tactic for their relatives' survival, even at the expense of their own safety, well-being, or reproduction.

Mass extinction The widespread and rapid dying out of an abnormally large number—at least half—of all species; this sharp change in biodiversity usually marks a shift to a new geological era in our planet's history.

Metabolism The chemical processes that occur within the cells of an organism to keep it alive, such as the processes that enable the digestion of food.

Metacommunity A set of independent communities that interact and are connected by the movement of some species between those communities.

Metapopulation A collection of smaller populations of a given species that are linked by the movement of some individuals.

Microorganism An organism, invisible to the human eye, that can only be seen with a microscope, such as a bacterium, virus, or fungus; also known as a microbe.

Migration A large-scale movement of a species from one environment to another; often occurs seasonally.